

exhilarating action on track by asking its drivers to maintain position and look to create a gap to Max Verstappen in third. The triggering of a Virtual Safety Car (VSC) allowed the Silver Arrows to escape an earful from the Italian and pit him for fresh rubber.

There were four cars and a gap of more than 15 seconds separating Russell from his main challenger now. But with his fading hard tyres, he knew he could not afford to slacken. Antonelli delivered near-perfection, lap after lap, to hunt down his teammate. A trip through the gravel at Turn 2, just as he looked to repass the Briton, threatened to thwart the dreamy ending. But Antonelli was not to be denied. He recovered almost immediately and

completed the final pass in his two-hour expedition to complete the storyline.

"It was quite scary during the moment," Antonelli said of his little heart-in-mouth excursion. "I thought I could still do the corner but once I went over a bit of gravel I went straight, and I was like maybe I've lost my chance. But then luckily we still had the pace and managed to bring it home."

In what was supposed to be a weekend of damage limitation following the out-of-allocation engine changes, Antonelli flipped the script to extend his lead atop the championship. The home win will no doubt be another shot in the arm for the young star who looks to defy expectation and reason, to zoom



Up next

In a quick turnaround, F1 heads straight to Madrid for the Spanish Grand Prix, scheduled for September 11-13.

towards the drivers' title.

But the effect of this race will be far heavier on Russell. It will require almighty mental fortitude from the 28-year-old to recover from a race defeat where he and his main rival on equal machinery were separated by almost the entire field. After Monza, Antonelli clearly holds all the cards.

« Unbelievable! I'm so happy. I could never have imagined to be here today, but we managed to pull it off. It's a dream coming true. What an incredible day. I couldn't do it without my team, family and everyone who supports me. Still a few races to go, so we're going to keep our head down, but now we're going to enjoy today – Antonelli »

